

By Amarnath K. Menon

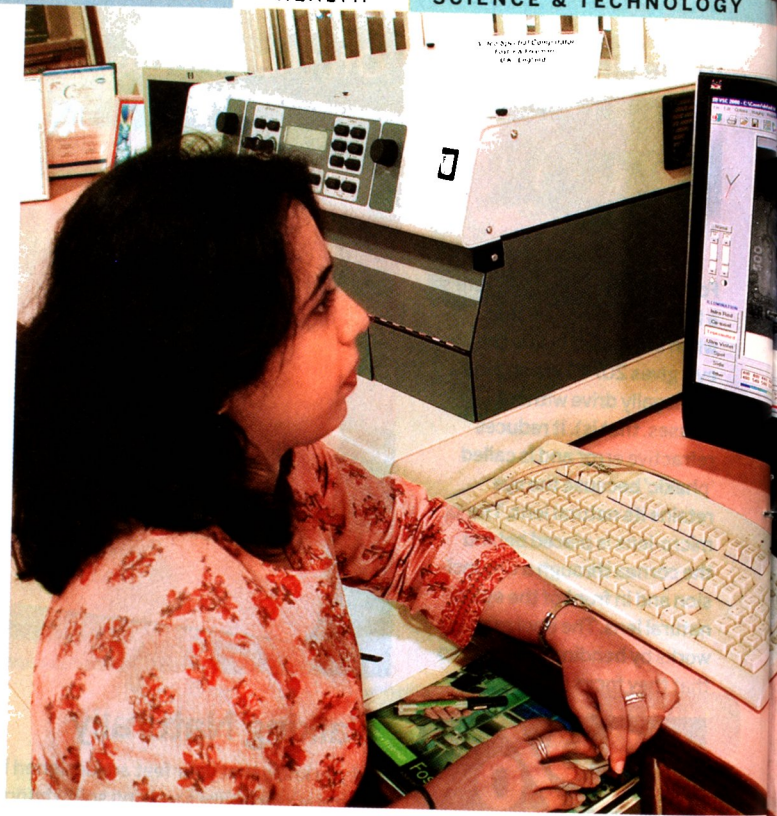
A leading Bollywood actress found her cheque book had been stolen and several cheques totalling Rs 10 crore had been issued, forging her signature. The suspect cheques were forensically examined and the forger was identified, making it possible to recover the money in a few days.

- A DNA test proved that a husband's suspicions about the paternity of his wife's second child were baseless, ending years of marital strife.

- Forensic examination of a will proved that it had been forged by an unscrupulous member of the family. The contents of the will had divided the family for over two generations.

- A leading industrialist was robbed of priceless family jewellery from his Delhi farmhouse. Fingerprint and forensic experts visited the site and, within three hours, identified the culprit who confessed to the crime.

Forensic science is the cutting edge of modern criminology and crime, and TV serials like *CSI* show us



Legal WEAPON

Evidence becomes sharper, and quicker, as India's first independent forensic laboratory makes an array of skills available to the police as well as citizens

just why. The above examples are all cases that were solved in a forensic laboratory with one surprising twist: they were processed at India's first independent, private forensic science laboratory (FSL). Truth Labs (TL) is a Hyderabad-based initiative involved in helping the victims of crime; one through forensic examination and collection to be passed on to the police, and the other by examining evidence referred by individuals, the police and courts. Be it examining documents, analysing fingerprints, DNA profiling, polygraph testing, au-

thenticating audio and video records, investigating a crime scene, screening a suspect from a psychological perspective or using any other probe to pinpoint the offender, TL is emerging as an effective investigating agency to complement existing government-run institutions. Private parties are using TL to resolve disputes that spring up over inheritance, forgery, impersonation, marital infidelity, and even corporate espionage. Being a

non-profit organisation and part of a public society called Truth Foundation adds to TL's credibility. After Hyderabad, it has also expanded to Delhi and Bangalore. Chennai and Mumbai are on the horizon too.

What's more significant is that TL is not just emerging as an alternate dispute resolution mechanism for out-of-court settlements but is pioneering proactive forensics, which is relatively unknown in India. For the first time

Forensic reports in seven days means investigations